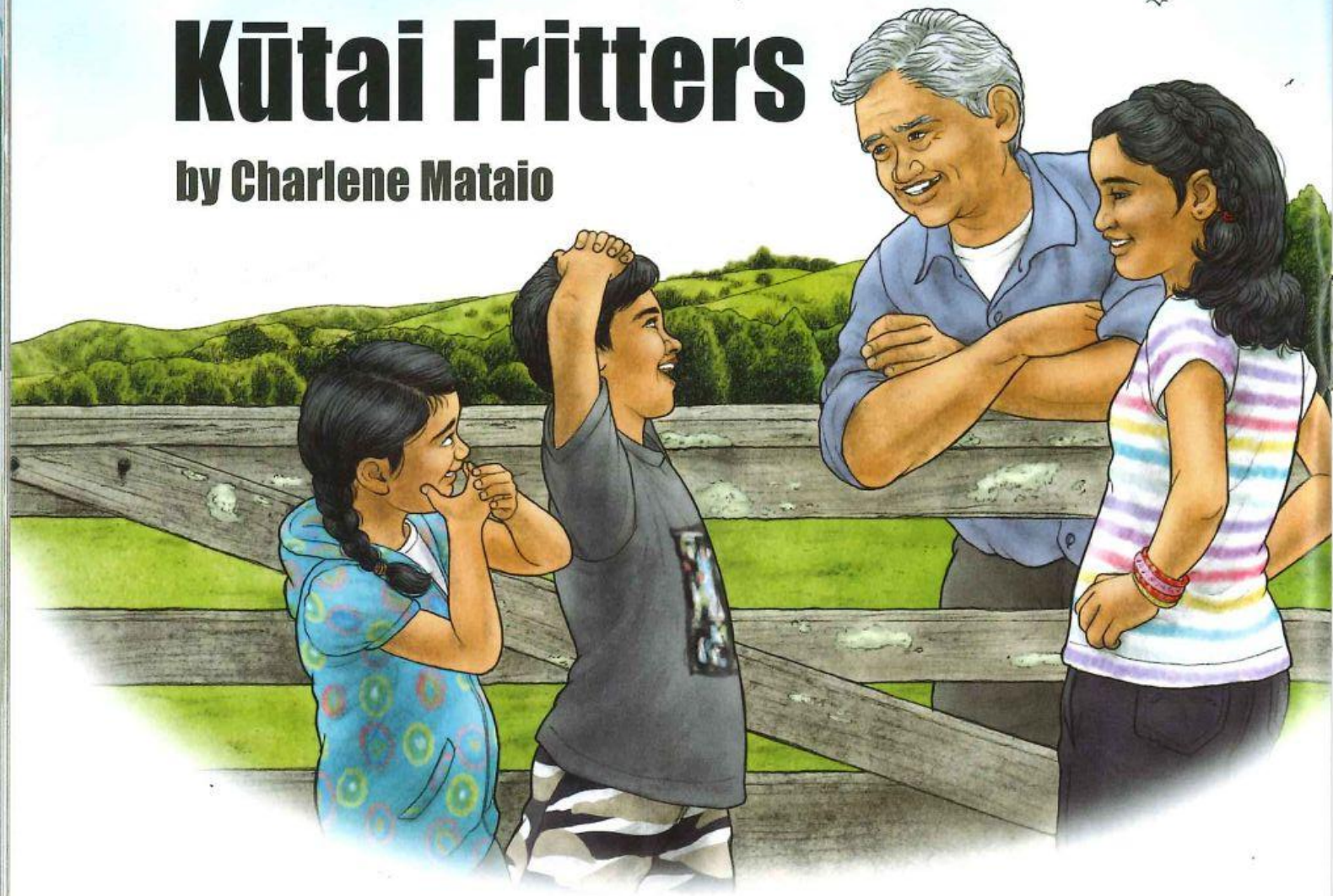


Kūtai Fritters

by Charlene Mataio



“Never turn your back on the sea when you’re collecting kūtai*,” my koro always warns us. “You never know when a wave will sneak up from behind and smack you on the bottom.”

We all crack up, but we know that what Koro says is true. I love kūtai fritters, but I don’t want to end up flat on my face in a rock pool.

Collecting kūtai always depends on the tides. Koro says that Tangaroa hides his tamariki well. There’s no way you’ll get near the kūtai beds when the tide is full.

* mussels

Low tide is best, but you need to give yourself time to get out to the beds, pick enough kūtai for a feed, and get safely back before the tide starts to come in again.

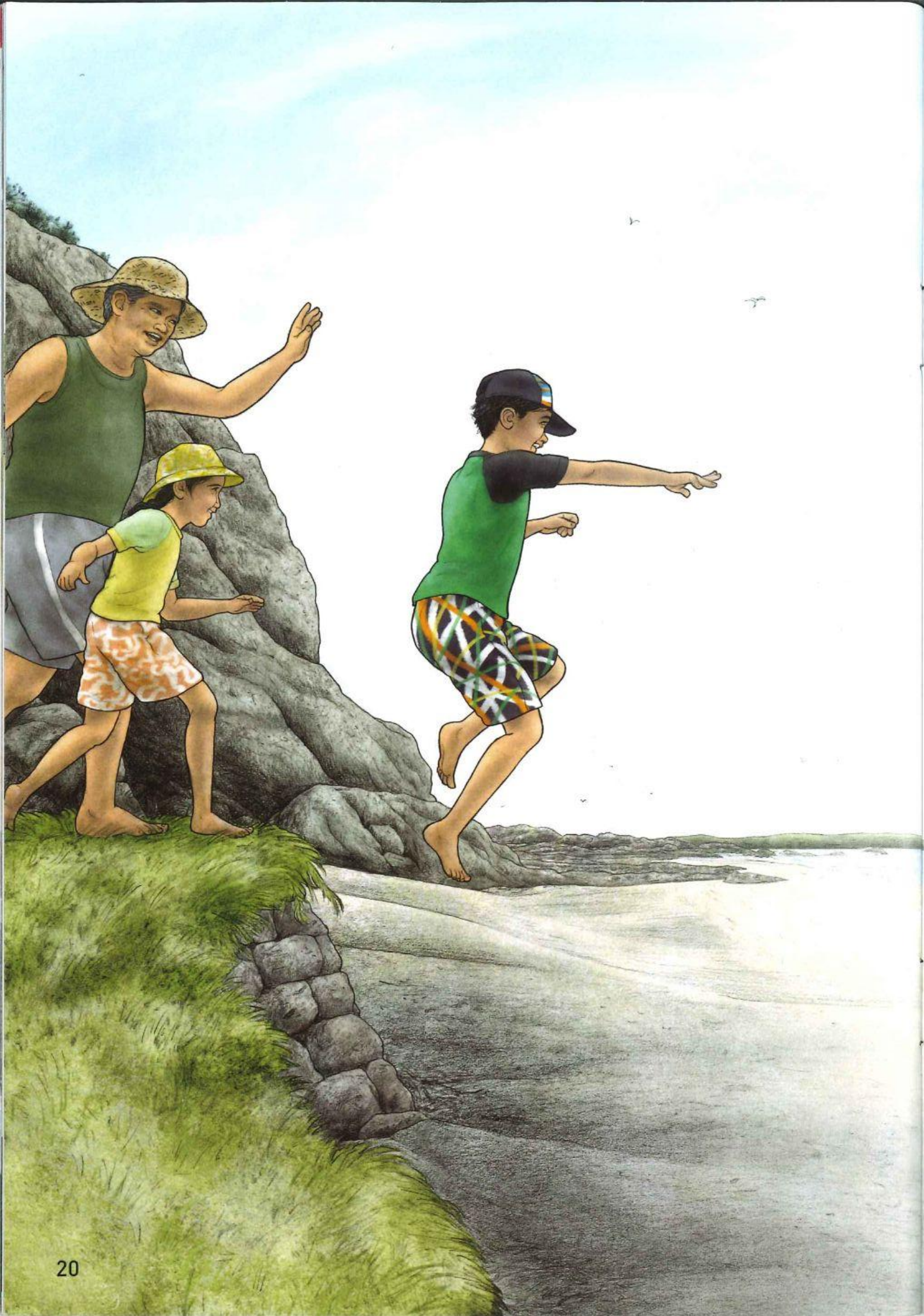
The best time of all is a king tide. That's when the tide goes out a lot further than usual and you can find masses of kaimoana. When there's a king tide, we always collect kūtai.

That's why, last Saturday, we were all getting ready to go to the beach. Mum made sure I had plenty of sunscreen on. Then I helped Nanny look for the big kete to put the kūtai in. My cousin Brianna helped my little sister, Maeva, to put her rash top on. Dad was looking for his sharp knife. Koro grabbed his favourite pōtae, which Nanny had woven for him. It flopped over his eyes, but it kept the sun off his head.

At last, everyone was ready.

“Who's going to find the biggest kūtai?” asked Koro.





“Me!” I yelled.

“No – me!” shouted Maeva.

When we got to the beach, I gasped. The tide was so far out! There were rocks I’d never seen before, and thousands of kūtai were glistening in the sunshine.

I jumped down from the wall and danced along the sand. It was scorching hot on my bare feet, and I raced off towards the cool water.

“Kalani,” called Koro. “Taihoa! Wait for the rest of us!”

I stopped, dancing from one foot to the other. I was impatient to get to the rock pools, but I knew that we needed to respect the moana. Tangaroa can be full of surprises, even at low tide.

We could smell the rock pools, fresh and salty. As we got further out, the sand changed colour from grey to light brown. I could feel its hard, moulded ripples under my feet.

Mum, Nanny, Brianna, and Maeva paddled in the shallow rock pools, looking for crabs. Maeva screeched with laughter whenever a kōtore moana* tickled her foot.

“Want to come with us?” Dad and Koro were carrying the kete out across the sand.

I nodded and followed them.

* sea anemone

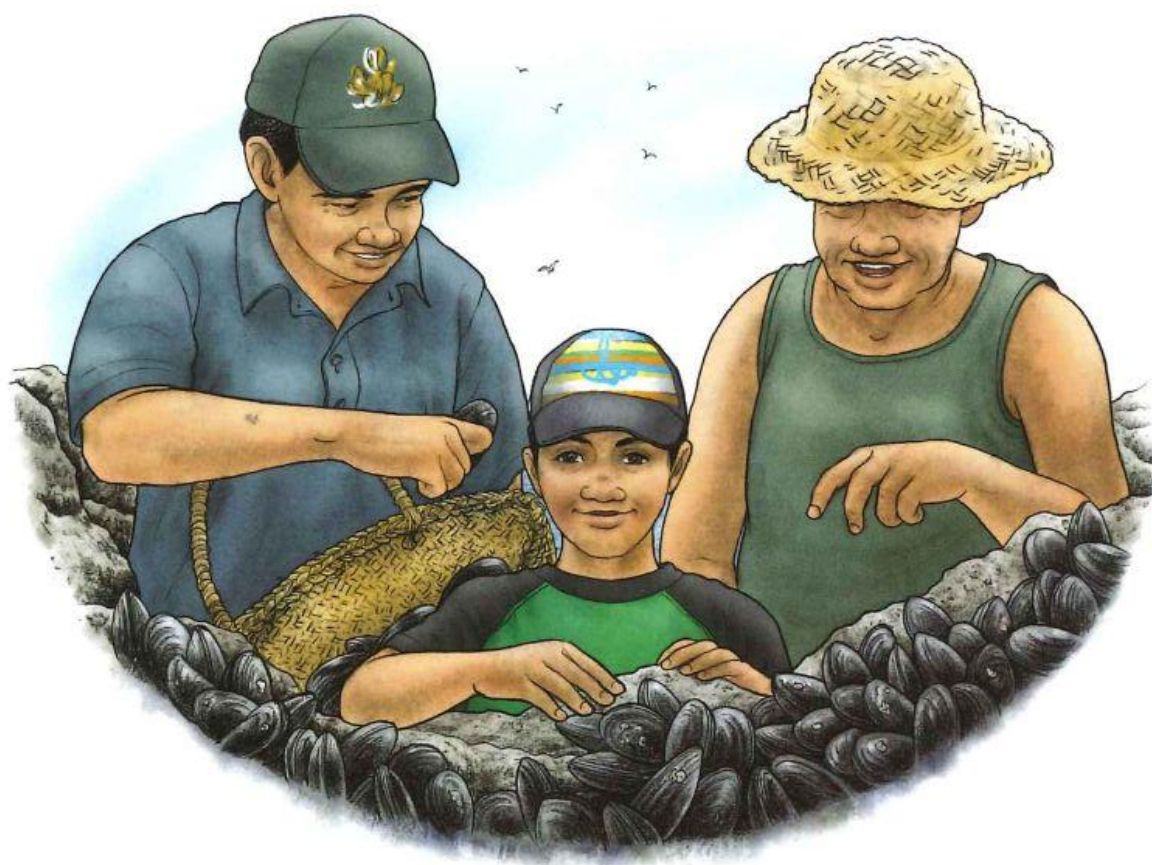
We were further from the beach than I'd ever been before. Out here, the pools were much deeper and darker.

I didn't want to admit it, but I was a bit scared of what might be hiding under the rocks.

Dad winked at me. "Haere mai, Kalani. Let's have a look over here." He led me towards a rocky ledge.

Clinging tightly to the ledge were the biggest kūtai I had ever seen. Some of them were bigger than my hand. Koro ran his fingers over them. "Let's get picking," he said. "And remember – we only take enough for a feed."

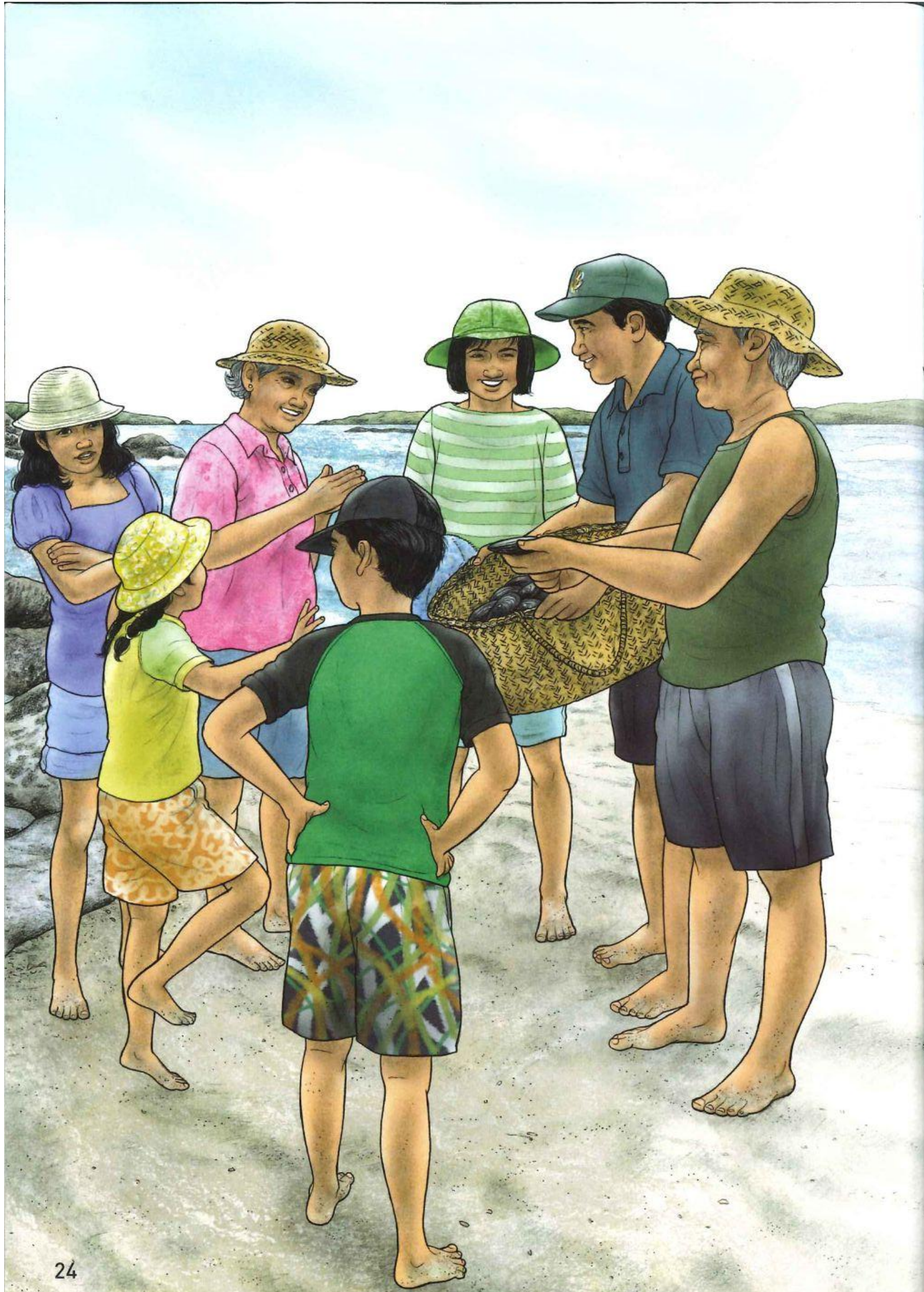
My mouth started to water as I helped Dad and Koro pull some of the biggest kūtai off the ledge and put them into the kete. Soon we'd gathered enough kai for our whānau.





But I couldn't stop wondering what might be in those rock pools. "Can we go over there and look?" I asked Dad.

He shook his head and pointed out to sea. I turned and saw that the first big waves were rushing into the deep pools. The tide was coming in again already.



“Sorry, Kalani,” he said. “It’s time to go.”

We picked up our kete and hurried back to find the others.

“Look what we’ve got,” I said proudly.

Mum and Nanny smiled when they saw how big the kūtai were. Maeva jumped up and down with excitement.

When we got home, Koro took his sharp knife and twisted it expertly to open a kūtai shell. Inside, it was bright orange, like the flesh of a pumpkin.

“That’s a good, fat, juicy one,” he said as the juice dribbled down his chin.

Dad caught my eye and winked. “Let Koro get a full puku now, eh?” he said. “Then he won’t eat as many fritters for tea tonight.”

I giggled, and Koro pretended to look hurt.

My cousin Brianna rolled her eyes. “Think about all the work we’ll have to do, Kalani, chopping up all those kūtai for the fritters. That always takes ages.”

I knew she was right, but I didn’t care. Today had been the best day ever. I couldn’t wait for the next king tide.

And next time, maybe I’d have enough time to find out what was hiding in those deep, dark rock pools.

illustrations by Elspeth Alix Batt